arguably giving the latter the luxury of taking a more frontal position vis-à-vis China. India does not enjoy this advantage; it is not just proximate but contiguous to China. Geographic proximity is believed to influence the threat perception two countries have towards each other.[80] On the one hand, geographic proximity could lead to balancing behaviour, but it could also motivate or necessitate a more cautious approach.

Even if a partnership with China will be difficult for India, given that China does not consider India on a par with it as an equal player, protracted conflict between the two will be expensive for both. It might be prudent for them to find a *modus vivendi* that is practical and workable. Manoeuvrings to outwit each other will be a wasteful exercise for both. While India should strive to avoid conflict with China, such an objective cannot be pursued at any cost. India must continue to engage China, as it is striving to do, in the hope that Chinese leaders recognise that cooperative behaviour is in their own self-interest.

This is not going to be easy, as China asserts itself in Asia and seeks to gain parity with the United States globally. Unless China back-tracks on establishing its primacy and embraces the idea of power-sharing, countervailing consultative mechanisms such as the Quad will inevitably develop sharper coordinated responses.[81] Without American presence and its determination to preserve a balance of power in Asia, it will not be possible to forge a cooperative security architecture in the Indo-Pacific region, with the ASEAN as its centre, in cooperation with other major Asian players. This does not mean, though, that India is ready or willing to turn its cooperation with the United States or the Quad into a formal alliance, even if India is now willing to embrace the term rather than to duck it.